

13 questions for the future of crowd work

In 2013, a paper born at CrowdCamp asked: *“Can we foresee a future crowd workplace in which we would want our children to participate?”* It mapped twelve research areas. For each one, here is the question we would ask today, with its premise taken from a paper in this week’s program, plus a thirteenth the paper left out.

Why now: Amazon Mechanical Turk shuts down on September 30, 2026, the last day of this conference. For three days, the people who study crowd work do it: you are the crowd.

CROWD WORK JOURNEYS

01 WORKFLOW

An agent workflow cut the first four design-thinking stages by 46% and did worse at reading users' emotions (Choi et al.). Which subtasks should stay with people?

02 TASK ASSIGNMENT

29% of tasks across the U.S. economy are already exposed to AI, a share growing 49% a year (Wright et al.). Who decides which tasks stay with people?

03 HIERARCHY

In Polymath Plus, an AI administers the discussion threads of human mathematicians (Michelucci et al.). When agents join a team, who manages whom?

04 REAL-TIME RESPONSE

AI support is immediate, and it lacks the lived experience that makes peer support meaningful (Goel et al.). When do we still need people on call?

05 SYNCHRONOUS COLLABORATION

Entrepreneurs turned to peers to verify AI-written business plans they could not judge alone (Zhao et al.). What does working together add when everyone has AI?

06 QUALITY CONTROL

Fluent AI explanations lead moderators to follow the AI even when it errs (Tuo et al.). Who catches AI failures, and how do teams calibrate trust?

COMPUTATION

07 CROWDS GUIDING AIS

LLMs reach near-human accuracy on objective annotation and remain error-prone on subjective tasks (Xu et al.). Who holds the harness when AI fails, bug-bounty style?

08 AIS GUIDING CROWDS

Annotation quality showed no clear difference between crowdworkers instructed by AI and by people (Libreros et al.). Where should people still steer?

09 PLATFORMS

MTurk sunsets on September 30, 2026, the last day of this conference (After MTurk panel). What replaces it, and what do workers get?

WORKERS

10 JOB DESIGN

Some work is ‘non-delegable’: its value lies in human responsibility and presence (Gupta). What work beside AI would we be proud to see our children do?

11 REPUTATION AND CREDENTIALS

Once AI help was removed, people did worse than their AI-assisted results suggested (Wu et al.). How do you build a track record when AI did half the work?

12 MOTIVATION AND REWARDS

On a 2026 bounty market, posted prices hide what workers must reveal to get paid (YeckehZaare). What should overseeing AI pay, and what if tokens stop being cheap?

NEW IN 2026

13 GOVERNANCE AND THE SOCIAL CONTRACT

A workshop here asks that affected communities hold ‘meaningful authority over outcomes’ (Ku & Wu). Who writes the social contract? Can crowds organize the way unions once did?



Pick one. Get your route.

1. Scan the code and choose the question you care about.
2. Get the sessions, talks and posters that match it, Monday to Wednesday.
3. Ask your question in Q&A. Then do the task: a comment, question or criticism on the talk, and when you think you will live in that future.

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